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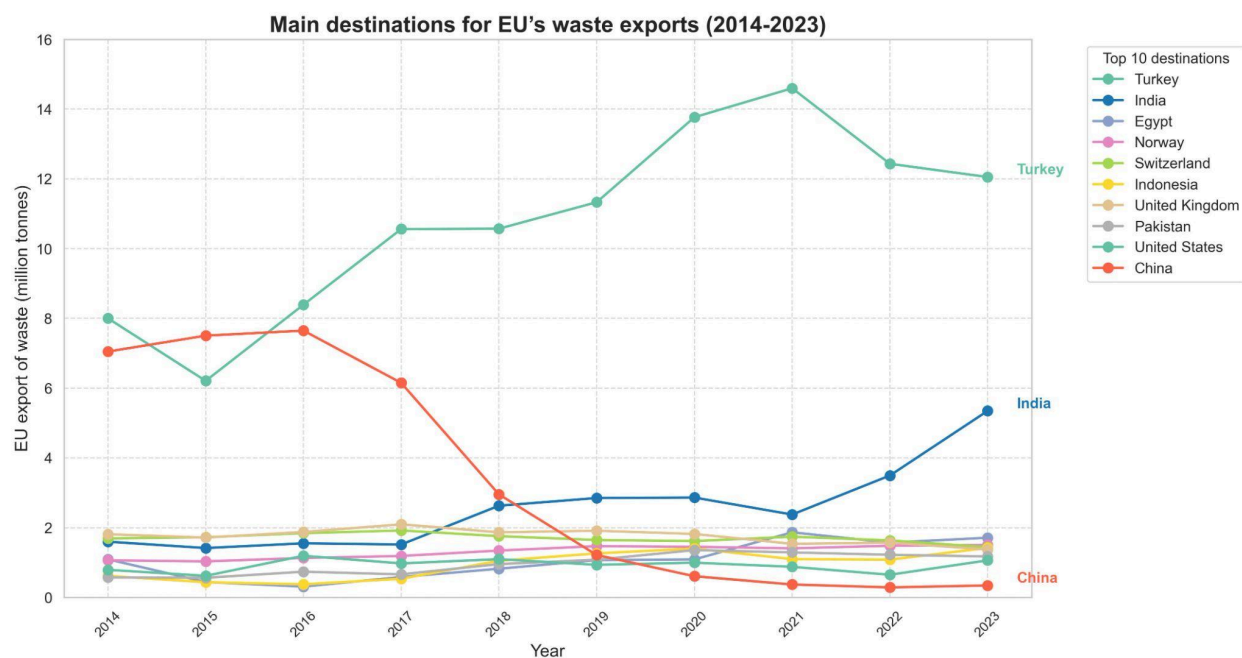
Europe's Waste Paradox: How Turkey Became the EU's Dumping Ground

By A. Sencer Gözübenli

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While Brussels obsesses over keeping bottle caps tethered to their bottles as part of its Single-Use Plastics Directive, championing sustainability and a circular economy with micro-level environmental reforms, a far greater waste crisis remains largely unaddressed: millions of tons of European waste being shipped to countries ill-equipped to manage it.

In April 2024, Eurostat [released](#) data revealing the EU exported over 35.1 million tonnes of waste in 2023 to non-EU countries, with Turkey [increasingly](#) serving as a primary destination. Since [China's 2018 ban on waste imports](#), the EU has shifted its focus to other markets, and Turkey, due to its geographical proximity, strong trade ties, weaker environmental enforcement mechanisms, and lack of transparency has emerged as a significant recipient. Yet this relationship, while convenient for EU nations, underscores a troubling reality: Turkey is fast becoming Europe's dumping ground, with catastrophic implications for its environment and public health.



Credit: A. Sencer Gözübenli | Source: Eurostat, [env_wastrdmp], https://doi.org/10.2908/ENV_WASTRDMP (2024)

Turkey's waste management infrastructure reveals a stark imbalance between capacity and “demand”. Despite years of escalating waste imports, Turkey’s recycling facilities can process [only about 1% of its own domestic waste](#) annually. The remaining waste is often untraceable, falling victim to a lack of oversight and accountability that has become a hallmark of the Turkish regime’s approach to environmental governance which has been deprioritized in favor of economic expediency.

The lack of transparency compounds the problem. Unlike the EU’s stringent environmental governance, Turkey has limited monitoring systems to track where waste is processed or disposed of, leaving citizens and environmental groups in the dark about its fate. This opacity is especially problematic for plastic waste, the most challenging and toxic form of waste to manage sustainably. [Investigations by Greenpeace](#) and other watchdog organizations have uncovered widespread malpractice. Plastic waste from countries like [the UK](#) and Germany has been found illegally dumped on Turkish roadsides, rivers, and farmland. In one striking case, thousands of tons of plastic from Germany were discovered near Adana, a city that has become emblematic of Turkey’s waste crisis. These dumps are hotbeds for pollution. Burning plastics releases toxic chemicals such as dioxins, which are linked to respiratory illnesses and cancer. Communities near dumping sites in Turkey face increased exposure to carcinogens and toxins. Moreover, [recent research](#) by the Stockholm University Institute for Turkish Studies highlights that the workers in Turkey’s plastic waste management facilities, some [as young as 9 years old](#), are handling potentially hazardous materials. This troubling situation is further fueled by the mislabeling of hazardous waste as non-hazardous or through other false declarations, allowing non-recyclable or difficult-to-recycle waste to be imported into the country.

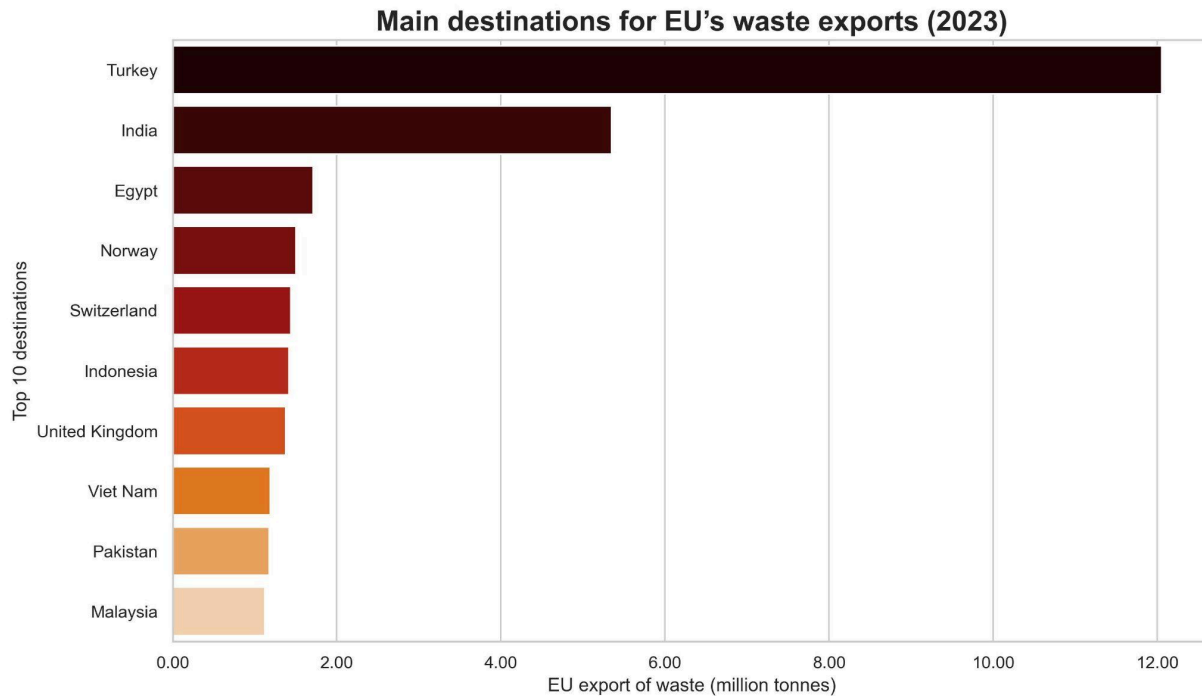


Waste dump at Karahan Kuyumcular, a village in the district of Seyhan, Adana Province, seen during an investigation into plastic waste that is dumped and burned in Turkey. The team found plastic packaging from UK, Germany, and global food and drinks brands and supermarkets.

Photo: © Caner GUEVERA / Greenpeace

The EU's waste trade with Turkey is not just an environmental catastrophe but a [humanitarian one](#). Illegal recycling practices often involve informal labor, exposing workers — including children — to hazardous materials without protective equipment. The economic and social costs of this trade disproportionately fall on Turkey's most vulnerable communities. Waste sorting in Turkey is not a structured part of municipal collection but is instead carried out by an informal workforce of [roughly half a million street collectors](#). These workers, among the most vulnerable in Turkish society, are increasingly made up of refugees from Syria and Afghanistan, who have fled war only to be exploited in Turkey's black-market recycling industry. Fighting for scraps in a ruthless system, they earn a mere €0.05 to €0.10 per kilo of waste, working from sunrise to sunset, with the bulk of the profits going to middlemen and processing plants. The Turkish government, which has tightened its grip on civil society and suppressed workers' rights, has shown little interest in regulating this industry or protecting those who labor in it. Refugees, who have limited legal protections and employment opportunities in Turkey, have no recourse when they are forced into dangerous, low-paying jobs under hazardous conditions. This exploitative system reveals an uncomfortable truth: These refugees—who were held in Turkey under a deal brokered by the EU itself—now serve as the cheap, disposable labor force propping up an industry that benefits both European waste exporters and Turkish oligarchs.

The EU, for its part, has been slow to act despite its well-documented awareness of the issue. While initiatives like the European Green Deal and the Circular Economy Action Plan seek to reduce waste and promote recycling, the high levels of waste exports highlight a reliance on externalizing environmental costs. Though the EU [banned](#) waste exports for disposal and hazardous waste exports to non-OECD countries by 2026 with the [Waste Shipment Regulation](#), Turkey's status as an OECD member allows it to remain a major recipient. This loophole reflects a troubling inconsistency in the EU's commitment to environmental sustainability. Data from Eurostat and the Basel Action Network shows that changes in regulations—such as Turkey's [ban on mixed plastic imports](#) in 2021—do little to halt the waste trade. Instead, exporters find alternative routes, often targeting countries with weaker regulatory frameworks. EU plastic waste exports to Turkey [increased to 35.4 million kg/month in July 2024](#) from 10.7 million in January 2023. That is equal to 224 truckloads of plastic waste per day.



Credit: A. Sencer Gözübenli | Source: Eurostat, [env_wastrdmp], https://doi.org/10.2908/ENV_WASTRDMP (2024)

Addressing this issue will require a combination of policy reforms, investment, and cooperation. The EU could consider further tightening its export rules to ensure that waste is only sent to countries with sufficient recycling infrastructure. Additionally, greater investment in domestic recycling capacity across Europe could reduce its reliance on externalizing waste by bolstering domestic recycling infrastructure and incentivizing innovation in waste reduction technologies. Public awareness is critical, as consumers deserve to know where their waste ends up. Labels on products could indicate whether they are likely to be recycled domestically or exported, and governments must ensure traceability of exported waste.

For Turkey, the challenge is twofold. Strengthening its waste management infrastructure and regulatory oversight, accompanied by greater transparency and accountability is a responsibility to its citizens to ensure that imported waste is processed safely and sustainably. Yet under Erdogan's regime, such reforms seem unlikely.

The EU-Turkey waste trade illustrates the complexities of managing waste in an interconnected world. While exporting waste can provide short-term relief for European countries, it also shifts the environmental burden to regions that may be less equipped to handle it. Striking a balance between domestic responsibility and international cooperation will be critical for ensuring that waste management practices align with the principles of sustainability and equity. The solutions are clear, but they require political will and collective action. Europe must confront its waste problem with the urgency it deserves — not by exporting it to Turkey and India, but by addressing it at home. Anything less is just morally indefensible.